military expenditure averaged 77 per cent of the budget; in Germany it was 91 per cent, in Russia 48 per cent, in the UK 49 per cent, and in the United States 47 per cent. During the Second World War the UK figure rose to 69 per cent and the US figure to 71 per cent.[56] Even during the détente years of the 1970s, Soviet military expenditure still amounted to 32.5 per cent of the budget.[57]

State budgets in more recent decades make for far more hopeful reading material than any pacifist tract ever composed. In the early twenty-first century, the worldwide average government expenditure on the military has been only around 7 per cent of the budget, and even the dominant superpower of the United States spent only around 13 per cent of its annual budget to maintain its military hegemony.[58] Since most people no longer lived in terror of external invasion, governments could invest far more money in welfare, education and health care. Worldwide average expenditure on health care in the early twenty-first century has been about 10 per cent of the government budget, or about 1.4 times the defence budget.[59] For many people in the 2010s, the fact that the health-care budget was bigger than the military budget was unremarkable. But it was the result of a major change in human behaviour, and one that would have sounded impossible to most previous generations.

The decline of war didn't result from a divine miracle or from a metamorphosis in the laws of nature. It resulted from humans changing their own laws, myths and institutions and making better decisions. Unfortunately, the fact that this change has stemmed from human choice also means that it is reversible. Technology, economics and culture are ever changing. In the early 2020s, more leaders are again dreaming of martial glory, armed conflicts are on the rise[60] and military budgets are increasing.[61]

A critical threshold was crossed in early 2022. Russia had already destabilised the global order by mounting a limited invasion of Ukraine in 2014 and occupying Crimea and other regions in eastern Ukraine. But on 24 February 2022, Vladimir Putin launched an all-out assault aimed to conquer the whole of Ukraine and extinguish Ukrainian nationhood. To prepare and sustain this attack, Russia increased its military budget far beyond the global average of 7 per cent. Exact figures are difficult to determine, because many aspects of the Russian military budget are shrouded in